

for free and unique third party plug-ins which further enhance the power of the suite and allow for more creative editing. The interface continues to surprise as the customisability of free-floating windows opens up more screen real estate for your project without sacrificing essential tools. The software also opens up as an educational environment for new users and allows for advanced projects with very little discernible quality loss - which makes it perfect for hobbyists and consumer - who typically work with very basic video equipment. In short Lightworks democratises the freedom to create video by saving users on money, hardware requirements and prior experience - all of which make it our natural choice for the number one open source video editing program.

Lightworks Pros

The extreme low weight system and the customisable interface distinguish the software in terms of user friendliness. The easy to learn system and its broad compatibility with codecs allow even less powerful machines to make the most of any video editing opportunity.

Lightworks Cons

Despite its open source origins Lightworks Free is just a stripped down version of a paid-for tool. And therefore it comes with a few restrictions which can prove annoying once you become serious about your projects. For example, the free version restricts users from exporting video in 1080p Full HD resolution and does not provide any DVD/BluRay authoring tools. In addition to which, the output is restricted to only H.264/MPEG-4 format. And while these restrictions don't hamper non-professional usage, they can very easily become a problem since cameras of nearly all types can now shoot in 1080p Full HD.

Honourable Mention: DaVinci Resolve Lite

The reason we place DaVinci Resolve Lite almost next to Lightworks is because of its truly impressive legacy. DaVinci Resolve, as a program, has worked wonders in international cinema and video, making some of the most amazing looking films. The best part is that it's available to users everywhere at no cost. This is something to be recognised. The newly incorporated editing suite included with Resolve Lite is fully professionally equipped and matches up with the industry best in terms of features and functionality. There is nothing that a user can do in FCP or Premiere Pro that couldn't be accomplished in Resolve Lite - at least within the realm of general video editing. While Resolve doesn't come with a sister compositing software (like Adobe After Effects) or FCP X's